
The Morning: The greatest living songwriters

"The New York Times" <nytdirect@nytimes.com>

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The New York Times The Morning

April 28, 2026



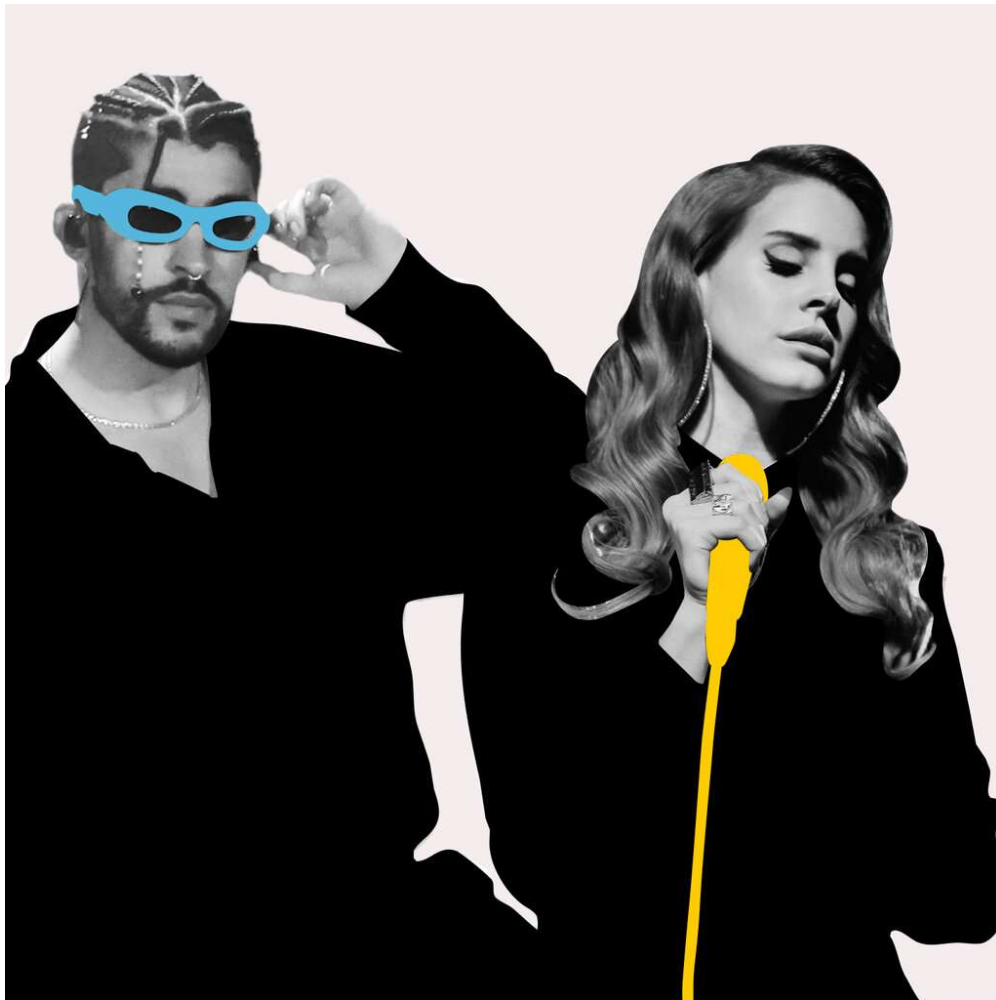
By **Sam Sifton**

Who's the greatest?

Good morning. You know what's a good way to start a conversation that's going to last a while? Publish a list of the 30 greatest living American songwriters. The Times [just did that](#).

First, we polled hundreds of pop stars, critics, historians, industry executives, D.J.s, music supervisors and choreographers. They gave us 700 names. ([Look at some of their ballots](#).) Then, during long and often heated conversations, six Times music writers edged the list down to 30 artists.

And now we need to talk about it! There's much to discuss. Because, sure, Bob Dylan's on the list, and Paul Simon and Bruce Springsteen, too. But Billy Joel didn't make the cut. Nor did Garth Brooks or Randy Newman. Yes to Stevie Wonder. No to Stevie Nicks. Everyone's going to have feelings about this. Everyone's going to cheer for some, bark at others, harrumph in complaint or declare vindication. (I was bummed about Nicks, but the methodology's sound. Here's [how they did it](#).)



What I like most about the project is the language behind the critical reasoning, the way enthusiasm can transform into concrete, and convincing, argument.

Take the river of hits Lionel Richie produced from the late 1970s into the mid-80s: “His litany of urgently treacly smashes was the soundtrack of that era,” writes Jon Caramanica. It was both an update of Brill Building songwriting and “a cool and controlled reimagining of the sensual soul music of the late ’60s through the mid-70s.”

Or Lana Del Rey: “Everybody wants to sound like her, but no one else can quite replicate the particular sonic grammar of her writing, which unfurls like an intimate dispatch from the blurry edge of sleep and wakefulness,” writes Lindsay Zoladz.

I like to luxuriate in arguments like these. Here are three now.

Taylor Swift

She had it right from the start, Joe Coscarelli writes, from the first verse of the first song of her first album: “He said the way my blue eyes shined / Put those Georgia stars to shame that night / I said, ‘That’s a lie.’”

Swift was 16. And in the two decades since, over 12 studio albums and hundreds of songs, she's distilled big feelings alongside melodies that worm their way into your brain. Joe's definitive about it:

Swift has done as much as anyone in modern popular music history to advance the idea of the song — its construction and impact, its tensions and limitations — as an important art form. But she has also done it while foregrounding the agency and emotional lives of young women, and as a result has become probably the most pored-over writer — or at least up there with J.K. Rowling and the pope — of the 21st century in any medium.

Swift gave us a rare interview about the craft of songwriting. Watch it [here](#). It's good: "There's a difference between art and, like, going and ranting on an Instagram Live. Like, there's a difference. This is a song. This takes craft, this takes skill, this takes expertise."



The New York Times

Jay-Z

Jay-Z's been a grown-up his whole career, writes Jody Rosen — a tactician, wise and worldly, dazzling in his storytelling:

Jay-Z's verses stacked up rhymes in intricate configurations — end rhymes, internal rhymes, half-rhymes, even nonrhymes that he twisted into rhymes through tricks of inflection. The language was dense, full of puns and double and triple entendres, but Jay's delivery was easeful, conversational; he rapped slightly behind the beat, giving the songs a subtle swing, a feeling of relaxed authority that lent credibility to tales of street hustling and forecasts of glory.

I wasn't in the room, but I'd like to think he walked onto the list with swagger and ease: "Brooklyn you nursed me / Schooled me with hard knocks, better than Berkeley."

Diane Warren

You may not know her name, but you've absolutely heard her songs: "Rhythm of the Night" for DeBarge; "Nothing's Gonna Stop Us Now" for Starship; "If I Could Turn Back Time" for Cher; "Un-Break My Heart" for Toni Braxton; "Say Don't Go" with Taylor Swift. Thirty-three of Warren's songs have made it to the Billboard Top 10. Nine hit No. 1.

Wesley Morris makes an excellent case for her greatness:

Warren practices a kind of off-the-rack designer extremism: I want you, I need you, you saved me, you left me, you found me, be gone, come back, you got me, you got this, I got me. She downplays anything much more specific because her music trusts its interpreters. The songs are silhouettes for a vocalist to customize, invest in and, in some of the best outcomes, eventually immolate. They're statements of often perverse confidence.

[Explore the list](#) and then [vote for your own personal greats](#).

And while you're at it, check out our lists of the 21st century's [100 best books](#) and [100 best movies](#). We're building a canon over here.

Now, let's see what's happening in the world.



We want to hear your questions about the news. That means anything The Times covers — maybe the peace talks in the Middle East, or the economics of the A.I. boom, or what’s happening in the midterm elections. We’ll find reporters to answer some for the newsletter.

[Send us your questions here.](#)

THE LATEST NEWS

Correspondents’ Dinner Shooting

The Justice Department formally charged the suspect in the shooting with [trying to assassinate President Trump](#).

The affidavit describing the charges did not say that the suspect shot a Secret Service agent.

Investigators [are examining posts](#) from the social media platform Bluesky in search of a motive in the attack.

Republicans in Congress argued that the attack is evidence that Trump [needs his new White House ballroom](#).

Trump and Melania Trump [demanded that ABC fire Jimmy Kimmel](#) over a joke about the dinner, delivered two days before it. (Kimmel said, “Mrs. Trump, you have a glow like an expectant widow.”)

War in the Middle East

Iran [made a new offer](#) to reopen the Strait of Hormuz if the U.S. lifted its blockade. Trump [wasn’t satisfied with it](#).

Hezbollah said it [would not give up its weapons](#) after a day of intense Israeli attacks in southern Lebanon.

Politics



Anna Rose Layden for The New York Times

King Charles, on the second day of his U.S. visit, [will address a joint session of Congress](#).

Staff at the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission say they are being pressured [to bring politically charged cases](#), even when there is little evidence.

Around the World



Sarah Mullally, the archbishop of Canterbury, and Pope Leo. Simone Risoluti/Vatican Media, via Reuters

The Vatican: Sarah Mullally — the first female leader of the world’s Anglicans — [prayed with Pope Leo](#). Catholics who support the ordination of women found the meeting encouraging.

South Korea: A.I. is making calls to check in on older adults who live alone. One woman said the technology [saved her life](#).

Russia: Politicians and influencers are speaking out against the Kremlin’s internet crackdown. It’s a [rare expression of political opposition](#).

Other Big Stories

This week Elon Musk and Sam Altman — once buddies, now enemies — will face off in a California courtroom. At stake: [the future of OpenAI](#).

A Massachusetts jury sentenced a woman to six months in jail for [unleashing bees](#) to fight an eviction.

OPINIONS

Tucker Carlson's comments about Israel [reflect a troubling turn in the American right](#), **Peter Beinart** writes.

Here are columns by **Michelle Goldberg** on [political violence](#) and **Thomas Edsall** on [A.I. and political ads](#).

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MORNING READS

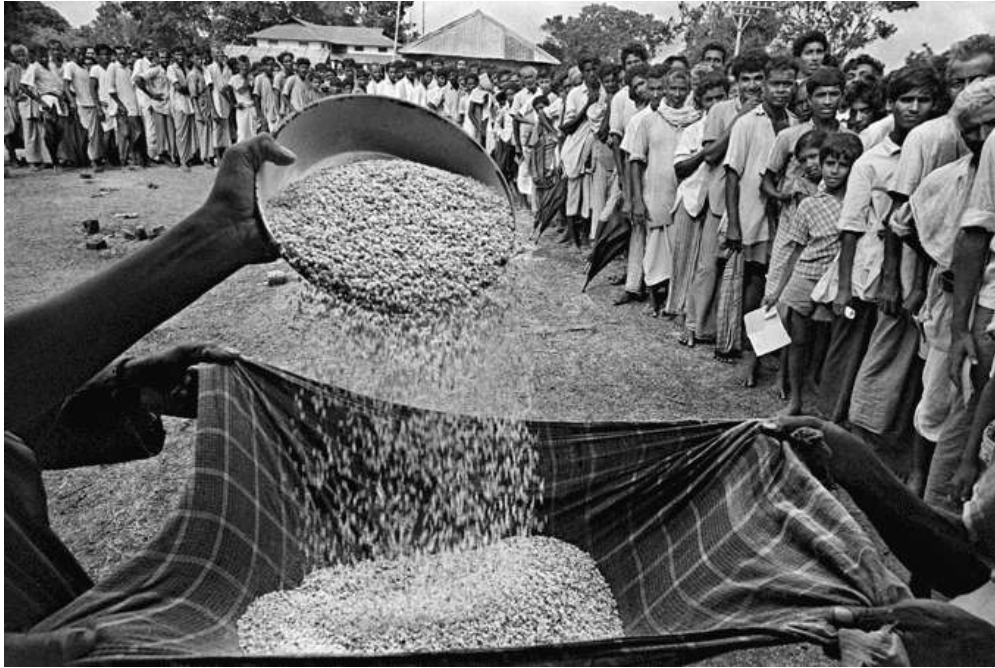


In Minnesota. Aaron Lavinsky/Star Tribune, via Getty Images

Paddling upstream: Take a journey through the pristine [Boundary Waters of northern Minnesota](#).

Your pick: The most clicked link in The Morning yesterday was [about a mysterious golden blob on the ocean floor](#).

Images of modern India: Raghu Rai documented life through photographs of major figures like the Dalai Lama, as well as victims of the Bhopal poison gas leak. [He died at 83](#).



Some of Raghu Rai's photographs. Raghu Rai/Magnum Photos

TODAY'S NUMBER

124

— *That is the number of researchers left in the Environmental Protection Agency's Office of Research and Development. More than 1,500 worked there a year ago. [Here's what happened](#) at the office, which studies public health.*

SPORTS

W.N.B.A.: Dallas Wings star Paige Bueckers said she had nothing to do with the team [selecting her girlfriend](#), Azzi Fudd, with its No. 1 draft pick.

Track and field: American track star Allyson Felix, 40, [is attempting a comeback](#) to compete in the 2028 Summer Games in Los Angeles, her hometown.

RECIPE OF THE DAY



Linda Xiao for The New York Times

Pete Wells brought this recipe for [Cuban-style black beans](#) to The Times in 2010, and I've learned a few things about it since. First, you can make it with canned black beans and it'll be exactly as delicious as it is if you simmer dried ones into tenderness. Second, you can make it with a jarred sofrito and it will be about half as good as if you cook your own. Serve over rice, ideally with hot sauce and fried sweet plantains. (Which hot sauce? I like one with body, like Tapatio, Frank's or Texas Pete.)

MICHAEL ON SCREEN



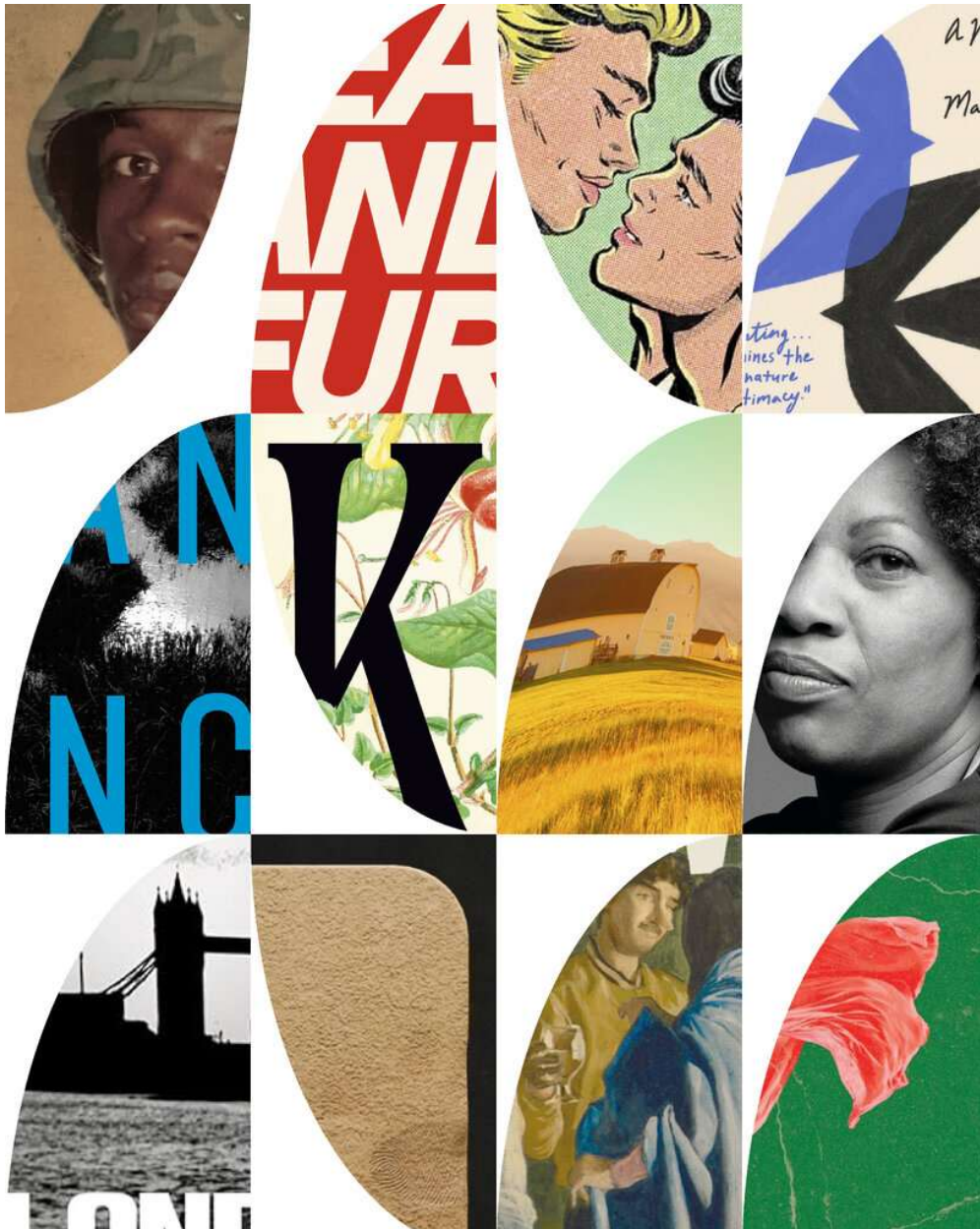
A Michael Jackson fan in Germany. Ebrahim Noroozi/Associated Press

Critics have largely savaged “Michael,” the Michael Jackson biopic. (The BBC [called it](#) a “bland and barely competent daytime TV movie.”) But it brought in more than \$200 million in ticket sales over the weekend, and fans danced in the aisles. The Times explored the discrepancy, heading to some showings to talk to [some of M.J.’s steadfast fans](#).

More on culture

Jamie Ding, a self-described “faceless bureaucrat” from New Jersey, [won 31 games of “Jeopardy” in a row](#), taking home more than \$800,000. His streak ended last night. Now, he’ll return to his hobbies, including running [an Instagram account rating General Tso’s chicken](#) with his sister.

Late night hosts [processed the White House correspondents’ dinner shooting](#).



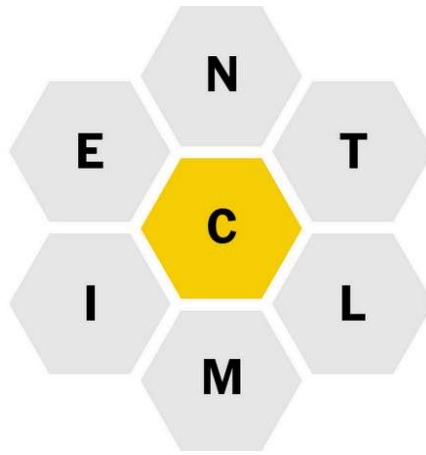
The New York Times

Read [the best books of the year](#) (so far).

Consider the small lifestyle changes Times readers made that have had [major effects on their health](#). (I like the guy who now gets off one station early during his subway commute and walks the rest of the way.)

Freeze more food and [you'll waste less of it](#).

GAMES



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangram was *legalizing*.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Connections](#), [Crossplay](#) and [Strands](#).

***Thanks for spending part of your morning with The Times and me.
See you tomorrow. — Sam***

P.S. On Friday, I wrote about my colleague Yewande Komolafe, a food writer who has battled sickle cell disease her whole life. I said she lost her legs and all but one of her fingers to the ravages of that disease. The amputations came about after what she called a series of medical errors during a long hospitalization.

Reach our team at themorning@nytimes.com.



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